IRON MAN MARK VI ARMOR



"That red-and-gold, what I think of as the 'lunchbox armor'—because it was on all the lunchboxes in the '60s and '70s—that was the suit for 20 years," says Tom Brevoort. While there was a change from the bulky initial model to a more streamlined, super hero-like armor, and there were relatively minor alterations in the armor periodically, "basically, that was the suit from '64, '65 to around '85."

But that would change. "The very first thing that came in, during the early '80s," Brevoort continues, "[classic Iron Man comics creative team] David Michelinie, Bob Layton, and John Romita Jr. hit on the concept of the 'specialty armor,' which is a perfectly obvious concept with a character like Iron Man, but nobody had done it before." That team developed the Space Armor, the Underwater Armor, and the Stealth Armor—purpose-built suits created for a specific task. "They started to adapt this idea and think about the suit as more than just a prop. From there, the next natural evolution became, okay—here's this year's model."





That constant movement has become a cornerstone of the Iron Man character. "It's really two things," says Kevin Feige, "One: his suit always evolves, he's always upgrading it, he's always coming up with new ideas and new gadgets for it. But, two: he's iconically red and gold and the face of Iron Man is more or less unchanged."

That color scheme wasn't always the case in the comics. For a while in the mid-1980s, the familiar colors were replaced by the "Silver Centurion" armor. That storyline, culminating with the new armor in Iron Man #200, was the introduction to the comic for current Invincible Iron Man comic book writer Matt Fraction. "My first issue was 198," says Fraction, "and two issues later he got a new suit so...in my head, that happened every three issues. He's the real, true, science-fiction super hero and he needs to constantly be upgrading and updating. It's part of the fun, and it resonates with his character."



One of the most synergistic elements between the comics and films has been the sharing of armor designers. While comic book artist—and creator of the then-most-recent armor—Adi Granov helped define the look of both Iron Man films, film designer Ryan Meinerding has just completed the design of the new comic book armor.

Adi Granov (left, center), Mark Bright (right).